Shootin' Creek

Old Time • Key of C • Low F Harmonica • 2nd Position • Fox Chase Form

Source: Franklin County, Virginia • Recorded by Charlie Poole (1928) & Henry Reed (1966)

Watch the Lesson

Notation: " = whole tone bend S = Scoop yah dah = fox chase tongue rhythm ... = sustained / = split (octave)

A Part — Play Twice

Basic Melody

```
-3 -4 yahdah -4 yahdah +5 -4  -3 -"3 -2
+5 -4  -3 -"3 -2
-"3 +3 +2 -1 -yahdah
```

2nd Time Variation

```
-3 -1 yahdah -1 yahdah +5 -4  -3 -"3 -2
+3 -"3 -3 -4 -3 -"3 -2
-"3 +3 +2 -1 +2 +3
```

B Part — Play Twice

Basic Melody

```
(+2 +3) -2 -3 -"3 -2
+3 -"3 -3 -4 -3 -"3 -2
+3 -2 -3 -"3 -2
-"3 +3 +2 -1 +2 +3
```

2nd Time — Leading Into High End A

```
(+2 +3) -2 -3 -"3 -2
+3 -"3 -3 -4 -3 -"3 -2
+3 -2 -3 -"3 -2
-"3 +3 +2 -1 yahdah
```

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High Register & Advanced Variations

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High End A Part — Play Twice

Basic Melody

```
(yahdah inhale -123)
-8 yahdah -8 yahdah +8 -8 -7 -6 +6
+8 -8 -7 -6 +6
+6 -6 +6 +5 -4  (yahdah -123)
```

2nd Time Variation

```
(yahdah inhale -123)
-8 yahdah -8 yahdah +8 -8 -7 -6 +6
-8 -8 -7 -6 +6
+6 -6 +6 +5 -4  (-3 -4 etc into A lower end)
```

High End B Part

```
-(123 yahdah) +6 +(567 yahdah)
-7 -6 +6 +5 +6
+7 -7 -6 +6 +5 +6
+6 -6 +6 +5 -4  (-123 yahdah)
```

Repeat

Advanced — Taking It Further

- Add adjacent notes to -3 and -3" for a fatter, more textured sound
- Replace -2 single note with -123 draw chord for rhythmic punch
- Change single notes to octave splits: -1/4 +2/5 +3/6 +4/7 -3/7 -4/8 +5/8
- Add tongue slaps to notes on the beat for drive and accent

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Shootin' Creek

Watch the Lesson

Origins

Shootin' Creek takes its name from Shooting Creek, a fast-flowing stream that rises in the Blue Ridge Mountains along the Floyd County–Franklin County line in southwestern Virginia and runs eastward down through Franklin County into the Virginia Piedmont. The hollow along the creek had a reputation as a prime moonshining locale in the early twentieth century — if Franklin County was the so-called Moonshine Capital of the world during Prohibition, then Shooting Creek might qualify as the Moonshine Capital of Franklin County.

The tune itself is closely related to Cripple Creek, one of the most widely played fiddle tunes in the Appalachian tradition. Alan Jabbour, the folklorist who recorded many of Virginia's great old-time fiddlers for the Library of Congress, identified Shooting Creek as a local variant especially popular among musicians along the Blue Ridge. It belongs to that simpler variety of fiddle tune that lends itself well to the banjo — and, as it turns out, to the harmonica.

Charlie Poole & Henry Reed

The most notable early recording came from Charlie Poole and The North Carolina Ramblers, who cut their version on 23 July 1928. Poole was one of the most important figures in early string band music — a banjo player from Spray (now Eden), North Carolina, whose recordings with the Ramblers helped define the sound of old-time music in the late 1920s. His version included lyrics, though the tune is almost never sung by fiddlers today.

The tune also appears in the Library of Congress as part of the Henry Reed Collection. Reed (1884–1968) was a fiddler from Glen Lyn, Giles County, Virginia, whose playing was recorded by folklorist Alan Jabbour in 1966–67 when Reed was over eighty years old. Reed recorded two sets of Shooting Creek that vary between themselves — one descends to a low D on the D-string in the second strain, while the other ends an octave higher. These recordings were made available online by the Library of Congress in 2000 as part of the Fiddle Tunes of the Old Frontier collection.

Playing This Tune

This version is played in second position on a Low F harmonica in the key of C. A Low F gives the tune a warm, rich tone that suits the old-time feel perfectly. It works well as a solo piece with a fox chase rhythm underneath, or with mellow instruments like a nylon string banjo. If you're playing with a fuller band, you may need to switch to a regular F to cut through the mix.

The structure moves between low and high registers. Start with the lower A and B parts to get the melody and the fox chase rhythm locked in. Once that's solid, take it up to the high end where the tune really opens up. The advanced variations add adjacent notes, octave splits, and tongue slaps for drive — build these in gradually once the basic melody is comfortable.

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